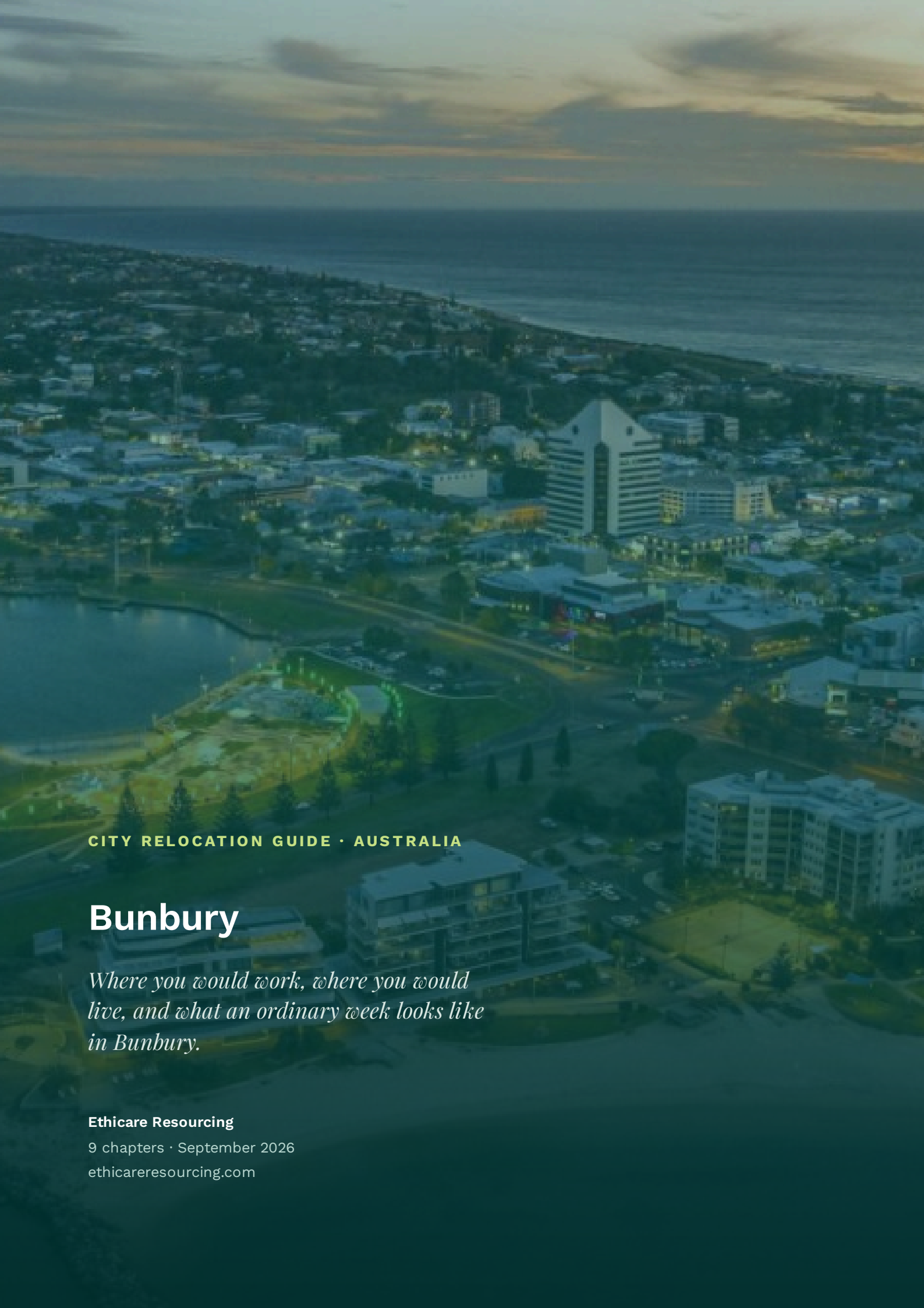


An aerial photograph of Bunbury, Australia, taken at dusk. The city is illuminated by streetlights and building lights, with a prominent white building with a pointed roof. The city is situated on a peninsula, with the ocean visible in the background. A large body of water, likely a lake or reservoir, is visible in the foreground on the left. The sky is a mix of orange, yellow, and blue, indicating the time is either dawn or dusk.

CITY RELOCATION GUIDE · AUSTRALIA

Bunbury

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Bunbury.

Ethicare Resourcing

9 chapters · September 2026

ethicareresourcing.com

What's inside

01 Welcome to Bunbury

02 Why Bunbury

03 Bunbury at a glance

04 Healthcare in Bunbury

05 Where clinicians live

06 Getting around

07 Cost of living

08 Food, the market & the everyday

09 Margaret River, Ferguson Valley & the weekend

This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Welcome to Bunbury

Bunbury Guide · Chapter 1 of 9

Bunbury is the city that makes the South West work: Western Australia's largest regional centre, two hours south of Perth, with a harbour, an estuary and a surf coast inside the same city limits. Here it is in nine numbers, then six things nobody tells you until you have moved.

A working port that turned outward

Around 75,000 people live across Greater Bunbury, on a stretch of coast between the Indian Ocean and the Leschenault Estuary. It grew up as a port — mineral sands, alumina and woodchip still move through it — and that industrial spine is why the city has infrastructure a place this size would not otherwise justify: a regional hospital, a university campus, a theatre, and a farmers' market people drive an hour to reach.

For clinicians the proposition is specific. The region's main public hospital is the South West's referral centre, taking work from district hospitals across a region roughly the size of Belgium. Alongside it sits a genuine private sector, including the only PET service anywhere in the South West. You get regional breadth without being remote: Perth is a two-hour drive, not a flight.

The honest costs: a smaller specialist bench than a capital, a referral list that runs upward to Perth for the most complex work, and a rental market that tightens fast when a big project staffs up. This guide prices all three plainly.

Who wrote this

We are a healthcare recruitment company, so we have an interest — but this guide is not a pitch. Nothing in it asks you to register, and there is no visa advice.

Bunbury suits people who want real clinical breadth and a coastline, and who would rather not pay Perth or Sydney prices for either. Where we think it is the wrong fit, we say so.

The city, in nine numbers

~75,000

People across Greater Bunbury — the largest urban centre in WA outside Perth.

2 hrs

To Perth by road on the Forrest Highway. A day trip, not an expedition.

175 km

South of the capital, on the Indian Ocean coast.

1

Referral hospital for the whole South West region.

Only

PET service in the South West — in the private sector, here in Bunbury.

50 min

To Busselton and the start of the Margaret River region.

30 min

To the Ferguson Valley and the Geographe wine country.

Regional

The South West's classification for skilled migration purposes.

3

Distinct waterfronts — ocean surf, a sheltered bay, and an estuary.

Six things you only learn once you are here

The geography does the work

Surf beach, sheltered bay and estuary are all inside the city. Which one you use depends on the wind, and you learn that in a fortnight.

Dolphins are residents, not an attraction

A wild population lives in Koombana Bay year-round. People stop noticing them, which is the most Bunbury thing about it.

It is a referral centre, not a district hospital

Work arrives from towns across the South West. The case mix is wider than the city's own population would suggest.

Wine country is a weeknight, not a weekend

The Ferguson Valley is half an hour inland. Margaret River is the trip you plan; Ferguson is the one you just do.

Winter is genuinely wet

The South West gets far more rain than Perth. People arriving from a dry climate are caught out by their first July.

Housing moves with industry

When a major project staffs up, rentals tighten quickly. Timing matters more here than in a big city.

A note on Country

Bunbury sits on Wardandi Noongar country, in the south-west corner of the Noongar nation. The Noongar name for this place is Goomburrup.

Acknowledgement of Country opens meetings and events across the region, and taking the time to learn whose Country you are on is genuinely appreciated here.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all about Bunbury specifically. Anything true of Australia generally — Medicare, visas, Ahpra registration, tax, superannuation, schools — lives once in [Moving to Australia](#), so you read it once and not nine times.

If you read nothing else, read [Why Bunbury](#) for the case honestly weighed, and [Healthcare in Bunbury](#), because the referral role is the part most people underestimate.

Why Bunbury

Bunbury Guide · Chapter 2 of 9

Most people who move here are trading a capital city for something with more coastline and less commute. That trade is real, and so is what you give up. Both sides, plainly.

What Bunbury is actually good at

Regional breadth, capital-city proximity

You take referrals from across the South West, but Perth is a two-hour drive when you want a tertiary opinion, a conference or a weekend.

Seniority arrives earlier

Smaller specialist benches mean your name is on decisions sooner than it would be in a metropolitan rotation.

A commute measured in minutes

Most people here drive ten or fifteen minutes to work. Over a career that is a different life, not a small convenience.

Housing that leaves room

Property costs materially less than Perth and a fraction of Sydney or Melbourne, which changes what a single clinical salary can carry.

Regional migration status

The South West is classed as regional, which opens skilled-migration pathways the capitals do not offer.

Three coastlines, one postcode

Surf on the ocean side, flat water in the bay, an estuary behind the town. You do not choose between them.

What to weigh up

None of the following should stop you. All of them are worth knowing before you sign, because they are the things people tell us they wish they had asked about.

Clinical

The bench is real but finite

Depth in your specialty exists, but it is a handful of colleagues rather than a department of thirty. Ask how many people sit alongside you specifically, not how many work in the hospital.

Clinical

Some work goes to Perth

The most complex cases are referred north. Which ones depends entirely on your specialty, and it is the single most useful question to ask at interview.

Practical

Rentals tighten with industry

Bunbury is a working port in a resources state. When a project staffs up, the rental market moves within weeks. Arriving with somewhere to stay for the first month is worth more here than in a capital.

Practical

Winter is wet, and that surprises people

The South West is the wet corner of a dry state. If you are arriving from the Gulf or from northern Australia, budget for a genuine winter.

Personal

It is a city of 75,000

There is a theatre, a university campus and good coffee. There is not the anonymity, the range of restaurants or the international airport of a capital. Some people find that a relief and some find it small; only you know which.

When another city is the better answer

If you need a large subspecialty team around you, or your work is concentrated at the most complex end, **Perth** is the honest recommendation – and it is close enough that Bunbury can be a later move rather than a rejected one. If you want a big regional referral centre with a bigger city attached, look at **Newcastle** or **the Gold Coast**. And if the draw is the South West itself rather than Bunbury specifically, the smaller towns south of here are worth a conversation, though the clinical roles thin out quickly.

“

Bunbury asks you to trade the size of the department for the size of the life.

What clinicians tell us, in one sentence

A typical week

A ten-minute drive to work. A swim or a walk on the ocean side before or after a shift, depending on the wind. Saturday morning at the farmers' market, which is a genuine institution rather than a nice idea. An afternoon in the Ferguson Valley half an hour inland, or the drive south to Busselton and the Margaret River region when you want a proper weekend. Perth when you want a concert, an airport or a Test match.

The short version

Bunbury gives you a referral centre's case mix, a fifteen-minute commute and three kinds of coastline, for materially less than a capital costs. What it asks in return is a smaller specialist bench and a two-hour drive to the nearest tertiary centre. If that trade appeals, very little else in Australia offers it at this price.

Where we'd steer you instead

If you need a tertiary bench beside you and formal training pathways, **Perth** is two hours north and the honest answer.

If you want the same regional-city trade closer to a capital, **Geelong** in Victoria plays a similar role an hour from Melbourne.

If the isolation is the part you are unsure about, the **Western Australia brief** sets out just how much further the state goes beyond here.

In our experience

Bunbury suits clinicians who want regional breadth without genuine remoteness — a real referral role, three waterfronts, and a capital close enough for a weekend. The people who thrive here wanted responsibility earlier than a capital would have given it to them.

Bunbury at a glance

Bunbury Guide · Chapter 3 of 9

Bunbury is easier to understand once you see that it is built on a peninsula between three bodies of water. Almost everything about the city — where people live, which beach they use, how long anything takes — follows from that.

The shape of the place

The city sits on a spit of land with the Indian Ocean on its western side, the sheltered water of Koombana Bay to the north, and the Leschenault Estuary running behind it. The centre is compact and walkable, the port sits on the bay, and the suburbs spread south along the coast and north across the estuary.

What that means in practice: your side of town determines your water. West means surf and wind. North means flat water and the port. Inland means the estuary, which is where most of the newer family housing has gone.

175 km

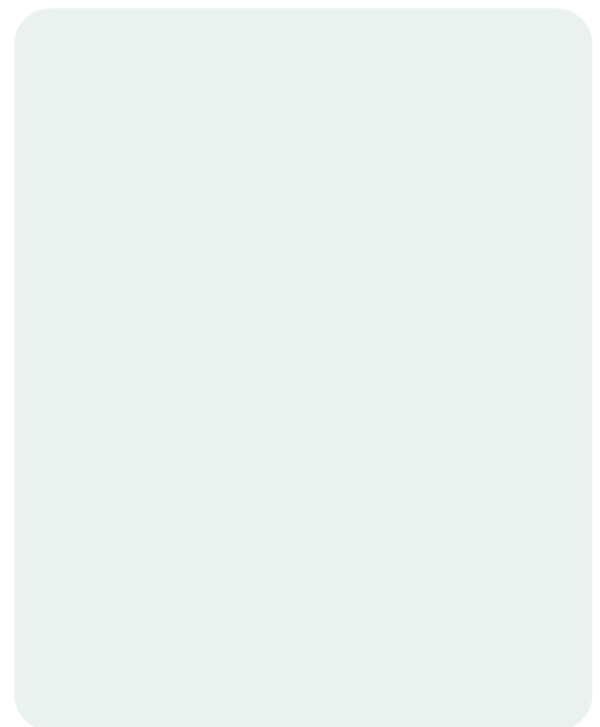
South of Perth

~75,000

Greater Bunbury

3

Waterfronts in one city



Where Bunbury sits, with the straight-line distance to Perth and Busselton

The seasons, honestly

This is the wet, green corner of Western Australia, and the difference from Perth is bigger than the two-hour drive suggests. Summers are hot, dry and long. Winters are cool and genuinely rainy — not cold by European standards, but wet enough to reshape your weekends from June to August.

Summer — Dec to Feb

Hot and dry, with an afternoon sea breeze that arrives most days and is the reason the western beaches empty out by four.

Autumn — Mar to May

The best of it. Warm water, settled weather, and the crowds gone from the coast south of here.

Winter — Jun to Aug

Cool and wet. Storms come in off the Indian Ocean, the estuary swells, and the inland valleys turn green.

Spring — Sep to Nov

Wildflowers inland, whales offshore on their way south, and the first swimmable days at the end of it.

How the city got here

Long before

Wardandi Noongar country

This is Goomburrup, in Wardandi country, part of the wider Noongar nation of Australia's south-west. The estuary and the coast have been lived on and managed for tens of thousands of years.

1830s

A port on the bay

European settlement followed the sheltered anchorage. The port has been the reason for the city ever since, and it is still working.

20th century

Timber, then minerals

Jarrah and karri went out through Bunbury, then mineral sands and alumina. The industrial base funded the roads, the rail and eventually the hospital.

Today

A regional capital that turned to face the water

The waterfront has been rebuilt around people rather than freight, a university campus arrived, and the city now serves the South West as its administrative, retail and clinical centre.

What is here that you would not expect

A regional referral hospital serving the whole South West

A university campus, with health among its programmes

A purpose-built regional theatre and entertainment centre

The only PET service in the South West

A farmers' market people drive an hour to reach

A resident wild dolphin population in the middle of town

Wine country thirty minutes inland

An art gallery in a converted convent

Orientation, in one line

A compact port city on a peninsula, two hours south of Perth, wetter and greener than the capital, with a referral hospital and a university that a city of 75,000 would not normally carry. Work out which water you want to live near, and the rest of the map follows.

Healthcare in Bunbury

Bunbury Guide · Chapter 4 of 9



Bunbury punches above its population clinically, for one structural reason: it is where the South West sends its patients. Understanding that referral role is the difference between reading this as a small-city job and reading it accurately.

The system

A regional referral centre

The region's main public hospital takes referrals from district hospitals across the South West, and provides the specialist services those towns do not carry.

District hospitals behind it

Smaller hospitals in the surrounding towns handle local and lower-acuity work, and refer inward when a case needs the specialist bench.

A genuine private sector

Private hospital and imaging services operate alongside the public system, including the only PET service anywhere in the South West.

Perth is the tertiary backstop

The most complex work goes north to the capital — two hours by road, and a normal part of how the region operates.

A note on names

We don't name hospitals, trusts or private providers as places of work anywhere on this site — a named employer implies a relationship, and the post and the package get confirmed with you directly.

Everything above is described structurally for that reason. If you want to know exactly where a role sits, ask us and we will tell you plainly.

What the referral role does to your work

A regional referral centre with a large, thinly populated catchment behind it pulls in two directions at once, and both are true of the same job.

What the region gives you

A case mix wider than the city's own population generates, because presentations arrive from across the South West rather than from Bunbury alone. Generalist breadth stays alive here in a way it often does not in a metropolitan subspecialty post.

What it asks of you

Comfort making decisions with a smaller bench beside you, and with distance in the system — some patients travel two hours to reach you, and some of your discussions with a tertiary colleague happen by phone.

Imaging and radiation, specifically

This is where our Australian work is concentrated, so it is the part we can speak to in most detail. The South West's imaging capability sits across both sectors, and the private side is more substantial than people expect for a city of this size — general nuclear medicine, PET-CT, and the modern gamma-camera and CT capacity that goes with it. For a technologist or radiographer that has a specific consequence: you are more likely to be operating across a wider range of modalities than you would in a large metropolitan department where the work is subdivided.

It also means training and cross-skilling tend to be available rather than theoretical, because a smaller service needs people who can cover more than one room.

[Profession guide](#)

[Radiographers in Australia](#)

[Ahpra registration, the pathway in order, and what the role is really like.](#)

[Profession guide](#)

[Nuclear medicine in Australia](#)

[The registration route for technologists, and what to expect from the work.](#)

[Profession guide](#)

[Sonographers in Australia](#)

[ASAR accreditation, the pathway, and indicative pay.](#)

[Profession guide](#)

[Radiation therapists in Australia](#)

[Recognition of your training, scope of practice, indicative pay.](#)

How pay works here

Registration is national but pay is not. In the public system, salaries are set by the relevant Western Australian health system industrial agreement, negotiated between the health service and the union covering your profession — so the same role can sit on a different scale in another state. In the private sector, pay is negotiated individually and is often higher, particularly where a service is hard to staff.

We do not publish figures we have not verified against the agreement that actually governs the role. For the indicative bands and how the frameworks work, see [Salary in Australia, explained honestly](#).

What to ask at interview

How far does this department's referral catchment actually extend?

Which cases go to Perth, and how is that handled day to day?

How many colleagues sit alongside me in my specialty specifically?

What is the on-call pattern, and how often is it genuinely called upon?

Which modalities or sub-specialties would I be expected to cover?

What CPD time and funding is provided, and does it cover travel to Perth?

Is there scope to cross-train, and is that supported or just permitted?

The short version

Bunbury is a referral centre, not a district hospital, which is why the clinical breadth is wider than the population suggests. The trade is a smaller bench and a two-hour road link to tertiary care – and for imaging specifically, a private sector deeper than you would expect at this scale.

Where clinicians live

Bunbury Guide · Chapter 5 of 9

Bunbury is small enough that nowhere is a bad commute, which frees you to choose on lifestyle rather than logistics. The real decision is which water you want to be near.

Make one decision first

Before you look at a single listing: fix your work site. The city's clinical sites are not all in the same place, and while nothing here is more than about fifteen minutes from anything else, the difference between a five-minute and a twenty-minute drive is worth knowing before you sign a lease rather than after.

Then choose your side. Ocean side means surf, wind and sunsets. Bay side means flat water, the port and the middle of town. Estuary and inland means the newest family housing and the most space for the money.

The areas, honestly

The city centre & Marlston

Apartments and townhouses, walking distance to the waterfront, restaurants and the entertainment centre. Suits people arriving alone or as a couple who want to be able to walk somewhere on a Friday. Least space per dollar.

South Bunbury & Withers

Established, close to the ocean beaches and to schools. Housing stock varies street by street — this is the area where it is most worth walking around before committing.

East Bunbury & College Grove

Quieter, greener, close to the university campus. Popular with families who want to be near good schools without paying a beachfront premium.

Dalyellup

South along the coast, newer estates, a young-family demographic and a genuine sense of community. A slightly longer run into town, and the trade most people are happy with.

Australind & Eaton

North across the estuary. The most space and the newest housing for the money, with the estuary rather than the surf on your doorstep. A ten to fifteen-minute drive in.

Gelorup & the rural fringe

Larger blocks, trees, and the closest thing to a small-holding within commuting distance. Suits people who want land and do not mind a car being essential.

Renting first is the sensible order

Almost everyone we place rents for six to twelve months before buying, and here there is a specific reason to. Bunbury is a working port in a resources state, and the rental market tightens quickly when a major project staffs up. Arriving with something secured for your first month – even short-term – takes the pressure off the decision that matters more.

How leases, bonds, applications and tenancy rights work is the same across Australia and is covered once in [Moving to Australia](#). Nothing about renting in Bunbury is legally different; it is the timing and the supply that are local.

Practical, in order

Fix your work site before you choose a suburb.

Decide your water: ocean, bay, or estuary and inland.

Rent for the first six to twelve months, and secure something before you fly.

Walk the street at the time of day you would actually be coming home.

If schools matter, check catchments before you sign – they do not always follow the suburb boundary.

The short version

Nowhere in Bunbury is a difficult commute, so choose on the life rather than the drive. Ocean side for surf, bay side for the middle of town, north across the estuary for space – and rent first, because supply here moves with industry rather than with the season.

Getting around

Bunbury Guide · Chapter 6 of 9



The honest summary: you will need a car, you will barely use it, and the drive to Perth is easier than people expect. Bunbury is a fifteen-minute city in every direction.

Inside the city

Almost every trip here is ten to fifteen minutes. There is a local bus network that covers the main suburbs and is useful if you live on a route and work regular hours, but it is not built for shift work, and most clinicians drive.

Parking is the quiet luxury. It is generally available and generally free, which after a capital city takes a while to stop noticing. Cycling works well on the flat coastal and estuary paths; less so in a South West winter.

~15 min

Most trips across the city

2 hrs

To Perth by road

~50 min

To the regional airport

Getting to Perth

By road

About two hours up the Forrest Highway, dual carriageway for most of it. Straightforward, and the reason a Perth weekend is a normal thing to do rather than a trip.

By train

A daily regional rail service connects Bunbury and Perth, taking longer than the drive but arriving in the middle of the city. Useful if you would rather not have the car at the other end.

By coach

Regional coach services run the corridor and the towns south of here, and are the fallback if you are without a car.

Flying

The nearest airport with scheduled flights is about fifty minutes south, with limited east-coast services. For most international travel you will drive to Perth.

The car question, answered plainly

Yes, you need one. Not because the city is hard to move around, but because the South West is the reason you came – and the wineries, the forests, the beaches south of here and the trailheads inland are not on a bus route. If you are a two-adult household, you will probably want two cars eventually, though plenty of people manage on one for the first year.

Licence conversion, importing a vehicle, insurance and registration all work the same way across Australia and are covered once in [Living in Australia](#). Nothing about it is specific to Bunbury.

First-month practicalities

Sort a car early – the regional used market is thinner than a capital's, so give yourself options.

Check whether your accommodation has off-street parking. Most does; it is worth confirming.

If you are commuting from Australind or Dalzellup, drive the route at your actual start time once before you commit.

Register for the rail service if you expect regular Perth trips – seats on the busy runs go early.

The short version

A car is essential and barely used inside the city. Fifteen minutes to anything local, two hours to Perth on a good road – and the car earns its keep on weekends, not on the commute.

Cost of living

Bunbury Guide · Chapter 7 of 9



Housing is the whole story. Almost everything else in Bunbury costs roughly what it costs in Perth, and a couple of things cost more – which is a more useful way to think about it than a single index number.

Why there are no dollar figures on this page

We publish rents and prices only where we have verified them against current data, and a figure that was true when a page was written is misleading a year later. Rather than print numbers we cannot stand behind, this chapter tells you the shape of the difference and where to check the current position yourself. For the national picture – tax, superannuation, Medicare, banking and what a first year actually costs – see [Money, tax & banking in Australia](#).

What costs materially less

BunburyHousing – the largest single difference

PerthNoticeably higher to rent and to buy

SydneyA different order of magnitude

Relative widths are illustrative of direction, not measured values. Check current listings and the ABS or state data before you budget.

Housing, rented or bought

The reason people move here and stay. What a clinical salary carries in Bunbury is not comparable to what it carries in a capital, and it is the difference that compounds over a career.

Parking and commuting

Generally free, and generally fifteen minutes. Two costs that quietly disappear when you leave a capital city.

Childcare and schooling proximity

Not necessarily cheaper per place, but you are far less likely to be paying for distance – the long drive, the before-school care that exists to cover it.

What costs about the same

Groceries, fuel, insurance, utilities, phone and internet all sit close to the Perth level. Australia is a national market for most of this, and Bunbury is a large enough centre to have real competition. Do not expect a regional discount on the weekly shop; do not expect a penalty either.

What costs more

Flying anywhere

The nearest airport with scheduled services is limited, so most flights start with a two-hour drive to Perth — and often a night either side. If you expect to fly home regularly, budget for that pattern, not just the fare.

Anything with a small local market

Specialist trades, some vehicle servicing, particular hobbies and equipment. Not dramatically, but the choice is narrower and that shows in price.

The one-off costs of the first year

These are the ones people underestimate, and they are the same wherever in Australia you land: visa and registration fees, flights, shipping or replacing furniture, a car, a rental bond, and the gap between arriving and your first pay. [Preparing to move](#) covers the national picture, and our [relocation cost calculator](#) will give you a personal estimate.

Where to check the current position

Current rental listings for the specific suburbs in [Where clinicians live](#) — the fastest reality check there is. State and ABS housing data for medians, rather than any figure on a recruiter's website.

Ask us what a role actually pays before you model anything. We will tell you the framework and the range.

The short version

Treat Bunbury as Perth prices with a materially cheaper roof over your head, plus a travel premium if you fly often. The housing difference is the entire argument, and it is a large one.

Food, the market & the everyday

Bunbury Guide · Chapter 8 of 9

The test of a place is not its best restaurant. It is what an ordinary Wednesday feels like, and whether Saturday morning has a shape. Bunbury does well on both, and one institution does most of the work.

The market is the centre of gravity

Bunbury's farmers' market is the thing locals mention first and visitors underestimate. It is not a weekend craft market with a coffee van; it is a large, working produce market that people drive in from an hour away to use, and it is open several days a week rather than being a Saturday event.

The practical consequence is that the South West's produce — which is excellent, this being the corner of the state that gets rain — is available at a price that makes cooking at home the default rather than the virtuous choice. People who arrive from a capital city tend to notice their grocery habits changing within a month.

Eating out, honestly assessed

What is good

Coffee, casual seafood, pub food that has improved a lot, and the waterfront and CBD strips where most of it is concentrated. For a city of 75,000 the standard is above what you would expect.

What is thinner

Range. There is not the breadth of cuisines a capital carries, and if you want a specific regional cooking you may be making it yourself. Perth is two hours away for the occasional fix.

Where the wine comes from

Thirty minutes inland in the Ferguson Valley, and an hour or so south in the Margaret River region. Local by any reasonable definition.

Where to find groceries from home

The main supermarkets carry more than they used to, and Bunbury has enough of a migrant population to support specialist grocers. For anything unusual, plan a Perth trip.

A week, once the novelty has worn off

Weekdays

A fifteen-minute commute and light left in the evening

The thing people mention most is not the beach. It is arriving home early enough for the evening to still be a thing that exists.

Saturday morning

The market, then the water

Produce first, then whichever coast the wind favours. This is the rhythm almost everyone falls into.

Saturday afternoon

Thirty minutes inland

The Ferguson Valley for lunch or a tasting, close enough that it does not need to be an occasion.

Sunday

South, or nothing at all

Busselton and the Margaret River region if you want a proper day out, or the estuary and a walk if you do not.

Finding your people

Bunbury is small enough that joining something is the fastest route in – a club, a surf group, a choir, a parents' committee. Clinicians consistently tell us the professional community here is close, partly because it is small: you will know the people you refer to, which changes how the work feels.

On the wider question of community, faith and belonging – and being honest that a smaller city means smaller communities than a capital carries – see [Community & belonging in Australia](#).

The short version

A serious produce market, good coffee, and eating out that is better than the population suggests but narrower in range. The real change is the shape of the week – a short commute buys back the evening, and that matters more than any restaurant.

Margaret River, Ferguson Valley & the weekend

Bunbury Guide · Chapter 9 of 9

This is the argument for Bunbury that needs the least explaining. You are living at the top of the South West, which is the part of Western Australia that everyone else drives four hours to reach.

Thirty minutes: the Ferguson Valley

Rolling green hills, small wineries and breweries, and a scale that makes it a casual afternoon rather than a planned trip. This is the one people underestimate before they move and use most after – close enough that you go without deciding to.

An hour south: Busselton and Geographe Bay

Calm, shallow, north-facing water and a jetty that runs a remarkable distance out to sea. This is where Bunbury families go when the surf coast is too rough for small children, and it is the gateway to everything further south.

Busselton, about fifty minutes south – the longest timber-piled jetty in the southern hemisphere.

Ninety minutes: the Margaret River region

The wine

One of Australia's most respected regions, and close enough to be a day trip rather than a holiday. Cellar doors, restaurants, and a scale that stays manageable.

The surf

Breaks along the coast, including the reef breaks that draw professional competition. Also plenty that is friendly to a beginner.

The caves and the forest

Limestone cave systems under the ridge, and tall karri forest inland. Good walking, and cool in a way the coast is not.

The coastline

The Cape to Cape track runs the length of it. You can do a section in a morning or the whole thing over a week.

An hour inland: Collie and the forest country

The other direction, and less obvious. Collie has become a serious mountain-biking destination, with purpose-built trail networks that draw riders from Perth, and the surrounding national park has dams, walking and the kind of quiet that the coast does not offer in summer. It is also the reminder that the South West is not only a coastline.

In the city itself

Surf and long walks on the ocean side

Flat, sheltered water in Koombana Bay
The resident wild dolphin population
The estuary for kayaking and fishing
The lookout for the sunset, which is a local ritual
A regional theatre with a real programme
An art gallery in a converted convent
Whale watching offshore in season

“

People drive four hours from Perth for the weekend you get by driving thirty minutes.

The South West, in one sentence

The short version

Wine country half an hour away, Busselton in fifty minutes, Margaret River in ninety, and mountain-bike trails an hour inland. Bunbury is not near the South West – it is in it, and that is the part that keeps people here after the job stops being new.

Where to next

The national guide

Moving to Australia

Visas, registration, Medicare, tax, schools and renting – explained once, for the whole country.

Two hours north

Perth

The capital, the tertiary centres, and the honest comparison if you are weighing the two.

Live roles

Current opportunities

What is open now across Australia, including the South West.

No pressure

Talk it through

Whether you are curious or close to deciding, a conversation costs nothing.